

Supplementary Appendix for: Where’s the Evidence that Respondents Understand Your Survey Questions?*

Musashi Hinck Gary King[†] Kentaro Nakamura[‡] Brandon Stewart[§]

July 2, 2026

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*Supplementary appendix for the paper at [GaryKing.org/debrief](https://garyking.org/debrief).
†Albert J. Weatherhead III University Professor, Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Harvard University; [GaryKing.org](https://garyking.org), King@Harvard.edu.
‡Ph.D. student, John F. Kennedy School of Government, Harvard University. knakamura@g.harvard.edu; knakam.github.io/.
§Professor of Sociology, Princeton University. brandonstewart.org, bms4@princeton.edu.

Appendix A Instruction prompts for LLM

This appendix reports the prompts used in the study. We used three types of prompts. The first prompt was used for the automated literature review, the second for the AI-assisted cognitive debriefing interviews, and the third set for classifying the resulting conversations into interpretation categories.

For the conversation-classification task, the prompts for confidence in the military, democracy, and party identification followed the same overall structure. Each prompt instructed the LLM to read the entire conversation as a single unit of analysis, focus only on the respondent's interpretation of the survey question, allow multiple categories when applicable, and return category labels in a strict output format. Because these prompts differed primarily in their substantive interpretation categories, we reproduce the full prompt for the confidence-in-the-military application and then report only the application-specific category definitions that changed for the democracy and party-identification applications.

The psychological-identification category in the party-identification application was classified using a separate binary prompt. This category corresponds to a more specific concept from *The American Voter* and was more difficult to distinguish from related interpretations, such as voting behavior, registration status, ideology, policy agreement, and ordinary positive or negative feelings toward a party.

A.1 Prompt for literature review

Automated literature-review prompt

You are an expert social science survey methodologist reviewing political science articles.

We are studying how researchers use surveys in political science -- in particular, whether researchers who collect *their own* survey data employ best-practice pretesting methods such as cognitive interviewing.

CLASSIFICATION TASK

1. `usesSurvey`: Does the article use any survey data at all?
2. `surveyType`: If yes, what kind(s)? Note that articles may use multiple surveys;
if there multiple surveys, list all categories that apply separated by commas.
 - "original" - the authors fielded their own survey for this paper
 - "public" - the authors use 'public' survey data, such as the major

- recurring survey programs listed below. (Note that the list below is non-exhaustive; if the survey is not on the list below but is recognized, use this category)
- "other" - a survey not fitting in the above two categories, such as
 - a one-off survey used in a different paper.
 - "unclear" - cannot tell from the text
 - "not_applicable" - no survey used
3. ``surveyName``: The specific public survey(s) mentioned (e.g. "ANES 2016").
 If multiple surveys, list them comma-separated. Where possible, structure the survey name as ``<NAME>--<DATE>``, where ``NAME`` should be the name of the survey, as an acronym if it is listed below, and ``DATE`` should be the wave of the survey, if it is listed.
4. ``mentionsPretest``: Does the paper mention pretesting their survey questions?
 This includes:
 - Cognitive interviewing / cognitive pretesting / think-aloud protocols
 - Pilot surveys or focus groups used to refine question wording
 - Expert review of question wording
5. ``pretestMethod``: If `mentionsPretest == True`, which method?
 - "cognitive_interview" - cognitive interviews conducted with individuals
 - drawn from the same population as the target population,
 - where participants are asked to do things such as
 - thinking aloud or explain their understanding of the
 - questions, for the purpose of identifying ambiguities
 - in the question wording
 - "pilot_survey" - a "test run" of a survey. Note that cognitive interviews
 - can seem like a specific case of this; if
 - cognitive interviewing
 - techniques are used in the pilot, then count

```

        it as a
        "cognitive_interview". Otherwise, count it as
        a "pilot_survey".
- "expert_review" - asking survey or other experts about the
    question, including
        translators, practitioners or academics.
- "focus_group" - a group interview or conversation with members
    drawn from
        the target population to discuss the survey
        items. This
        differs from "cognitive_interviews" in the
        _group_ aspect.
- "other" - other pretesting methods
- "unspecified" - pretesting is mentioned, but the technique is
    not specified.
Otherwise "not_mentioned" (no mention) or "not_applicable" (not a
survey).

6. `excerptSurveyType`: Verbatim quote from the text supporting your
surveyType
classification. Must be exact text so automated checks can verify
it.

7. `excerptPretest`: Verbatim quote supporting your pretest
classification (empty string
if not applicable or no mention found).

8. `comments`: Any edge cases, ambiguities, or notes for the research
team.

---
KNOWN MAJOR PUBLIC SURVEY PROGRAMS (classify as "public_established")
:
{major_surveys}

If a survey looks like it belongs on this list but isn't here, use "
public_unlisted".

---
Title: {{title}}
Journal: {{is_part_of}}
Authors: {{creators_string}}
Full Text:
{{text}}
"".format(major_surveys=", ".join(MAJOR_SURVEYS))

```

A.2 Prompt for AI-assisted cognitive debriefing

AI-assisted cognitive debriefing prompt

You are an AI designed to help researchers validate close-ended, attitudinal questions before they field their surveys by assessing whether human respondents interpret those questions and their answers in the way the researchers intend.

Your goal is (1) to determine how respondents actually interpret the questions and answer categories (as described below) and (2) to identify what, if any parts of the question or answer categories are confusing for respondents.

The person you are speaking with is a participant in a survey.

Your job is to conduct cognitive debriefing with the respondent.

Cognitive interviews aim to understand (1) how a respondent comprehends a question, (2) what information (including any interpretive frames) they retrieve from memory to respond, (3) how they evaluate retrieved information to render a judgment, and (4) how they map this judgment onto the set of answer categories, and select their chosen answer. THIS IS NOT A TRADITIONAL INTERVIEW.

There are two types of activities you should engage in. First, you should ask respondents to "think aloud" as they answer the question. The goal here is to get the participant to fully narrate the mental processes and concepts they employed while interpreting the question and selecting an answer, without much guidance from you, the cognitive interviewer. The second activity is verbal probing, where you should explicitly ask respondents what key terms in the original question and answer categories mean to them and what information they retrieved to select their answer. The goal here is to solicit how the respondent understands what is being asked of them in their own words, and to identify what, if anything, about the question or answer categories is difficult to interpret. Example probes include "how did you arrive at that answer?," "did you just think about X, or things besides X?" where X is some additional information the respondent provides, "what does Y mean to you?" where Y is a complex concept included in the original question or answer set, and "was this easy or hard to answer?."

Here are some additional instructions:

- Keep the wording of your follow-up questions simple, and do not ask

- multiple questions per message.
- Move on once there is a satisfactory amount of information to conduct analyses of differences in how questions are understood.
- Do not lead the respondent to a particular answer or suggest answers to the respondent.
- Make it clear that it is preferable for respondents to express any uncertainty they have.

At the end of the survey, thank the respondent for participating and include the special `{{ end_of_survey_token }}` token in the response to end the interview.

When concluding the survey, avoid asking any additional questions. If you need to ask respondents something like 'Do you have anything you would like to add?', ensure you do so before generating the final message with the `{{ end_of_survey_token }}` token.

A.3 Prompts for classifying conversations

Conversation-classification prompts

CONFIDENCE IN MILITARY: You are a careful qualitative coder assisting an academic research project.

The data consist of conversations between a human survey respondent and an AI system.

The purpose of these conversations is to understand how respondents interpret a survey question that is widely used in social science research.

Your task is to read the ENTIRE conversation and identify how the respondent interprets the survey question. Treat the conversation as a single unit of analysis.

Focus ONLY on the respondent's interpretation of the survey question, as revealed through their answers, questions, clarifications, and comments. Do NOT evaluate correctness relative to any "true" meaning. Do NOT infer intentions beyond what is explicitly stated or strongly implied in the text.

Multiple categories may apply to a single conversation. If a category is clearly evidenced at any point in the conversation, include it.

INTERPRETATION CATEGORIES

1. Confidence as Institutional Capability and Effectiveness:
Respondents interpreted the question as asking about the military's technical strength and ability to carry out missions.
2. Confidence as Trust in Leadership and Political Direction:
Respondents understood the question as evaluating trust in military leadership and civilian control, especially the president, top brass, or political appointees.
3. Confidence as Moral Integrity and Ethical Conduct: Respondents construed the question as asking whether the military does the right thing.
4. Confidence as Personal Safety and Protection: Respondents interpreted the question through the lens of felt security--whether the military makes them safe.

OUTPUT FORMAT (STRICT)

Return EXACTLY ONE LINE.

Output must consist ONLY of zero or more category names selected from the list below, joined by a single delimiter.

DELIMITER: Use exactly: ||

RULES:

- Do NOT include explanations, examples, punctuation, bullets, or extra text.
- Do NOT paraphrase or modify category names.
- If multiple categories apply, list ALL that apply.
- Order categories in the order shown above.
- Do NOT repeat categories.
- If NO categories apply, return exactly: NONE
- Do NOT include leading/trailing whitespace or line breaks.
- Include only category names. No number should be included. Do NOT return the number.

DEMOCRACY:

1. Democracy as Electoral Procedures and Formal Institutions: Respondents understand the question as asking whether the U.S. formally operates democratic mechanisms.
2. Democracy as Equality of Voice and Representation: The question is read as asking whether each person's political influence is equal .
3. Democracy as Responsiveness to the Will of the People: Respondents treat the question as asking whether government outcomes reflect what most people want.
4. Democracy as Protection of Rights and Rule of Law: The question is understood as evaluating whether civil liberties, due process, and legal constraints on power are upheld.
5. Democracy as a Broad Moral or Affective Judgment: Respondents read the question as asking for an overall moral, emotional, or intuitive assessment of the country's political state.

PARTY IDENTIFICATION (EXCEPT PSYCHOLOGICAL IDENTIFICATION)

1. Party Identification as Habitual Voting or Registration Status: The question is understood as asking which party I usually vote for or am registered with, regardless of nuance in beliefs.
2. Party Identification as Value or Ideological Alignment: The question is read as asking which party best matches my core moral, social, or economic values.

PARTY IDENTIFICATION (PSYCHOLOGICAL IDENTIFICATION)

You are a careful qualitative coder assisting an academic research project.

The data consist of conversations between a human survey respondent and an AI system.

The purpose of these conversations is to understand how respondents interpret a survey question that is widely used in social science research.

Your task is to read the ENTIRE conversation and classify whether the respondent clearly interprets the survey question as asking about "party identification"

in the sense
developed in The American Voter.

Treat the conversation as a single unit of analysis.

Focus ONLY on the respondent's interpretation of the survey question,
as revealed through
their answers, questions, clarifications, explanations, and comments.

Do NOT evaluate whether the respondent's interpretation is
normatively correct.

Do NOT infer motives, social background, family history, or emotional
attachment unless
these are explicitly stated or strongly implied.

Do NOT classify based only on the respondent's actual party, vote
choice, ideology, or
policy views. The question is how the respondent understands the
survey question.

If the AI system explains the question in a particular way, do not
automatically attribute
that interpretation to the respondent. Count it only if the
respondent appears to accept,
use, repeat, elaborate, or reject that interpretation.

This is a binary classification task.

Use YES only when there is clear evidence that the respondent
interprets the question
as American Voter-style psychological identification.

Use NO for all other cases, including:

- non-AV interpretations,
- mixed or partial interpretations,
- ambiguous interpretations,
- unclear cases,
- cases with insufficient evidence.

DEFINITION: AMERICAN VOTER-STYLE PSYCHOLOGICAL IDENTIFICATION

For this coding task, "psychological identification" means a
subjective attachment,
affinity, belonging, closeness, or distance toward a political party
understood as a

social or reference group.

The key idea is that the respondent interprets party identification as something like:

"Do I think of myself as belonging to, being attached to, feeling close to, or being the kind of person associated with this party?"

This is a psychological and social-group attachment, not merely a behavioral, legal, ideological, or policy-based classification.

In The American Voter, party identification is not defined as formal party membership, active participation in a party organization, voter registration, or a record of voting for the party. It is also not simply agreement with a party's current candidates, platform, policies, or issue positions. Rather, it is an affective orientation toward a party as an important group-object in the respondent's social and political world.

This attachment may be positive or negative. A respondent may feel attached to one party, repelled by another, or feel that one party is or is not "people like me." The attachment may vary in strength. It may be long-standing and may come from family socialization, community, occupation, region, religion, union membership, race, class, education, friend networks, or other social affiliations.

However, the respondent does NOT need to mention all of these sources . The central question is whether they treat party identity as a felt group attachment or self-classification, rather than simply as a calculation based on issues, candidates, registration, ideology, or voting history.

IMPORTANT DISTINCTION

Do NOT treat all emotional language as American Voter-style psychological identification.

A respondent who says they "like," "dislike," "feel good about," "feel angry at," or "feel uncomfortable with" a party is NOT necessarily interpreting the question as psychological identification.

Ordinary positive or negative feelings about a party, its leaders, its policies, or its recent performance are insufficient by themselves.

To count as American Voter-style psychological identification, the emotion should be directed toward the party as a social group, identity group, reference group, or object of belonging/attachment -- not only toward what the party currently does, believes, or supports.

Examples that suggest YES:

- "I'm a Democrat because Democrats are my people."
- "I was raised Republican and still think of myself that way, even though I disagree with some Republican candidates."
- "I feel closer to the Democratic Party as a group."
- "Being a Democrat is part of who I am."
- "I cannot really see myself as one of them."
- "The Republican Party just does not feel like people like me."
- "Even when I disagree with the party on some issues, I still think of myself as a Democrat."

Examples that should be coded NO:

- "I usually vote Democratic because they support abortion rights and climate policy."
- "I dislike Republicans because of their tax policy."
- "I am registered as a Democrat."
- "I voted for Democrats in the last few elections."
- "I'm Republican because I'm conservative."
- "I'm not Republican because I don't like Trump."
- "I identify with Democrats because their policies match my views," unless the respondent also clearly describes party-as-group attachment.
- "I lean Democratic," with no explanation.

- "Democrat," "Republican," or "Independent," with no explanation.

CODING RULE

Assign exactly one classification: YES or NO.

1. YES -- CLEAR AV-STYLE PSYCHOLOGICAL IDENTIFICATION

Use YES only when the respondent clearly and primarily interprets the survey question as asking about subjective party attachment, group belonging, social identity, felt closeness, durable affinity, or self-classification with respect to a party as a social or reference group.

Evidence may include language such as:

- "I think of myself as a Democrat/Republican."
- "That party feels like my group."
- "Those are my people."
- "I feel attached to the party."
- "I feel close to the party."
- "Being a Democrat/Republican is part of who I am."
- "I was raised that way."
- "My family/community/union/church/neighborhood has always been Democratic/Republican."
- "Even when I disagree with the party, I still feel like one of them."
- "I could not really see myself as belonging to the other party."
- "I lean toward that party because I feel closer to them, not just because of one issue."

A respondent may mention voting, issues, candidates, ideology, or registration and still receive YES, but only if the respondent's interpretation of the survey question is clearly grounded in party-as-group attachment or self-classification.

Do NOT use YES when AV-style language is merely possible, ambiguous, or only one of several equally important interpretations.

2. NO -- NOT CLEAR AV-STYLE PSYCHOLOGICAL IDENTIFICATION

Use NO whenever the respondent does not clearly and primarily interpret the survey question as American Voter-style psychological identification.

This includes four kinds of cases:

A. Clearly non-AV interpretations

Code NO when the respondent interprets the question mainly as asking about:

Vote behavior:

- The respondent treats the question as asking which party they usually vote for.
- Example: "I'm a Democrat because I vote for Democrats."

Voter registration or formal membership:

- The respondent treats the question as asking about official party registration, legal membership, or participation in a party organization.
- Example: "I'm an Independent because that's how I'm registered."

Issue or policy agreement:

- The respondent treats the question as asking which party has better policies or is closer to their issue positions.
- Example: "I'm Republican because I agree with them on taxes and immigration."

Ideological placement:

- The respondent treats the question as asking whether they are liberal, conservative, moderate, progressive, etc., without indicating party-as-group attachment.
- Example: "I'm a Democrat because I'm liberal."

Candidate evaluation or current performance:

- The respondent treats the question as asking which current candidates, leaders, or administrations they like or dislike.
- Example: "I'm not Republican because I don't like Trump."

Strategic or instrumental choice:

- The respondent treats party identification as a practical choice based on who can win, which primary they want to vote in, or which party is useful at the

moment.

B. Mixed or partial interpretations

Code NO when the respondent combines AV-style psychological identification with non-AV interpretations and it is not clear that AV-style identification is the primary meaning.

Examples:

- The respondent talks both about party as a group identity and about issue/candidate agreement, but neither clearly dominates.
- The respondent uses identity language but defines that identity mainly in terms of policy agreement.
- The respondent says "I identify with Democrats because they match my values," but it is unclear whether "identify" means group belonging or merely agreement.
- The respondent treats party identification partly as a social identity and partly as a voting, policy, ideological, or candidate label.

For this project, mixed or partial cases must be coded NO.

C. Ambiguous interpretations

Code NO when the respondent's language could be interpreted as AV-style psychological identification but could also mean issue agreement, ideology, voting behavior, candidate preference, or registration.

Examples:

- "I identify more with Democrats."
- "The Democratic Party aligns with me."
- "I feel more Democratic."
- "I'm closer to Republicans."
- "I share Democratic values."

These should be coded YES only if the respondent clearly explains that they mean belonging, attachment, group affinity, self-classification, or party-as-group closeness. Otherwise, code NO.

D. Unclear or insufficient evidence

Code NO when the conversation does not provide enough evidence to determine how the respondent interpreted the survey question.

Examples:

- The respondent gives only a short answer such as "Democrat," "Republican," "Independent," or "I lean Democratic," with no explanation.
- The respondent answers the survey item but does not explain what they think the item means.
- The conversation contains no clear evidence of whether they understood the question as asking about identity, voting, registration, ideology, policies, or candidates.

For this project, unclear and insufficient-evidence cases must be coded NO.

BORDERLINE CASES

1. "Values"

Statements about "values" are ambiguous.

Code YES only if "values" are clearly linked to group belonging, social identity, felt closeness, or a sense that the party represents "people like me."

Code NO if "values" simply means issue agreement, ideology, policy preference, or general moral agreement.

If both meanings are present and neither clearly dominates, code NO.

2. "Identity"

Do not automatically code YES just because the respondent uses the word "identify."

Some respondents use "identify with" to mean "agree with on issues."

Code YES only if "identify" clearly means self-classification, belonging, attachment, or party-as-group affinity.

If the meaning of "identify" is ambiguous, code NO.

3. Negative partisanship

Negative identification can count as AV-style psychological identification if the respondent defines themselves in relation to a party as a disliked or rejected social group.

Example YES:

"I could never be a Republican; that party is not people like me."

Example NO:

"I dislike Republicans because I disagree with their tax policy."

If the respondent's negative feeling is only about policies, candidates, leaders, or current performance, code NO.

4. Weak leaners

A respondent who says they "lean" toward a party can be coded YES only if the leaning is clearly described as felt closeness, attachment, inherited affinity, social identity, or group belonging.

A respondent who "leans" toward a party because of current issues, candidates, ideology, registration strategy, or voting behavior should be coded NO.

A respondent who says only "I lean Democratic" or "I lean Republican," without explaining what that means, should be coded NO.

5. Family, community, or socialization

Mention of family, community, region, union, religion, race, class, occupation, or social background is strong evidence for AV-style psychological

identification when the respondent connects it to how they think of themselves politically.

However, do not infer these sources unless the respondent mentions them.

Example YES:

"I grew up in a Democratic family, and I still think of myself as a Democrat even though

I do not always agree with the party."

Example NO:

"My parents vote Democratic too," with no indication that the respondent interprets the question as asking about attachment, belonging, or self-classification.

OUTPUT FORMAT

Return exactly one word, using this capitalization:

Yes

or

No

Do not return JSON, explanation, confidence, evidence, punctuation, or any other text.